#AI4ELECTIONS HACKATHON 2026 - 2027: CALL FOR APPLICATIONS

Following the success of Run-Am, an AI-powered misinformation detection and fact-checking mobile app developed by Rise Networks for the 2023 Nigerian elections, **Rise Networks**, in collaboration with the **Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC)** and other partners including the **International Centre for Investigative Reporting (ICIR)**, **Google**, **Microsoft**, **Meta**, **NITHUB at the University of Lagos**, **the Centre for Information Technology and Development (CITAD)**, **CLEEN Foundation**, **Tap Initiative for Citizens' Development**, **International Press Centre (IPC)**, **Legal Naija, Ahmadu Bello University** and **Federal University of Akure (FUTA)**, with support from the **MacArthur Foundation** and **Luminate**, invites eligible Nigerians to apply for the **#AI4Elections Hackathon**, a national, multidisciplinary and nonpartisan programme designed to bring together Nigeria's technology ecosystem, electoral experts, researchers, universities, developers, innovators and civil society to design and develop practical, responsible technology solutions for electoral integrity, transparency, inclusion and democratic participation.

Applications open: Thursday, 22nd October 2026
Application deadline: Thursday, 12th November 2026, 11:59 p.m. WAT
Grand Finale: 16th December 2026
Prize pool: ₦10 million
Apply at: https://ai4elections.risenetworks.org

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WHAT IS THE #AI4ELECTIONS HACKATHON?

This is a nonpartisan electoral innovation Programme for participants ready to move beyond conversations about AI and elections to design, develop, test and demonstrate what responsible technology can create for credible, people-centered, innovation driven elections. Can AI help citizens access reliable electoral information? Can technology improve electoral data analysis, strengthen information integrity, support election observation or make civic participation more inclusive? Rise Networks has designed the #AI4Elections Hackathon to bring together Nigerian developers, researchers, students, academics and innovators to some of these address these challenges and develop practical, responsible and locally relevant solutions.

WHAT WILL PARTICIPANTS GAIN?

Selected participants will have the opportunity to:

- **Compete for cash prizes:** Share in the **₦10 million** prize pool through the overall competition awards and special innovation awards and win Laptops and other Tech Devices.
- **Develop their technical skills:** Participate in virtual bootcamps, mentoring and technical workshops.
- **Pursue further development:** Promising teams may be considered for the **#AI4Elections Development Hub**, subject to selection, for further technical validation, product refinement and mentorship.
- **Build professional connections:** Join the **#AI4Elections Community of Practice**, connecting developers, researchers, universities, civic organizations, mentors and technology partners working on responsible electoral technology
- **Microsoft Azure Credits:** Access to Azure cloud credits to support prototyping, testing and development of their AI solutions, subject to applicable terms and allocation limits.

#AI4ELECTIONS HACKATHON TRACKS

The competition will focus on five principal tracks:

1. **AI and Trustworthy Electoral Information:** Solutions for detecting, assessing and responding to AI-generated or manipulated electoral information, synthetic media, impersonation and misleading content.
2. **Electoral Data Analysis, Operational insights & Decision Support:** Responsible AI applications for analyzing authorized electoral datasets, improving data quality, processing public documents, supporting logistics analysis and identifying data anomalies for human review.
3. **Inclusive and Multilingual Electoral/Civic Technology:** Accessible voter-information tools, Nigerian-language civic and electoral information, assistive interfaces and technologies that address barriers to participation.
4. **Electoral Cybersecurity and Resilience:** Defensive tools, authorized simulations, security monitoring concepts, privacy-preserving systems and approaches that strengthen the resilience of electoral technology.
5. **Election Observation and Citizen Accountability:** Tools for structured observation reporting, incident documentation, civic feedback, public information access and transparency, with appropriate safeguards for citizens and observers.

Optional Crosscutting Area – Climate Resilience and Environmental Innovation: AI and emerging technology solutions addressing climate-related challenges affecting electoral accessibility, civic participation, information integrity and public accountability. Applicants may incorporate this area into any of the five existing tracks, it is not a separate Hackathon track

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Solutions should demonstrate a clear and justified use of artificial intelligence or other relevant emerging technologies in addressing any selected electoral challenge. The technology used should be appropriate to the problem, with consideration given to accuracy, security, authenticity, privacy, accessibility and practical usefulness.

ELIGIBILITY REQUIREMENTS

- **Nationality:** Applicants must be Nigerian citizens aged 18 or above.

This Hackathon is open to:

- University students, recent graduates and postgraduate researchers.
- Developers, AI engineers, data scientists and cybersecurity professionals.
- Researchers, lecturers and independent scholars.
- Women, vulnerable groups and persons with disabilities, who are strongly encouraged to apply.
- Startups, technology entrepreneurs and civic tech innovators.
- Electoral experts, election observers and civil society practitioners.
- Product designers, accessibility specialists, linguists and communication researchers.
- Public policy, governance, legal and data protection professionals.
- Emerging innovators.

Application Format

- Apply as an individual or as a team of up to 4 members.
- All applications must be submitted in English.
- Each team member must register individually and be identified as part of the same team before the deadline.
- Each individual may participate in only one entry.
- Team membership cannot be changed after the Hackathon begins.
- Individual applicants may participate in structured team matching.

PROGRAMME TIMELINES

- **Applications open:** 22nd October 2026
- **Application deadline:** 12th November 2026
- **Application data cleaning and eligibility checks:** 13th-16th November 2026
- **Technical and Programme screening**: 13th-16th November 2026
- **Shortlisting and notification of selected participants**: 13th-16th November 2026
- **Participant onboarding and hackathon kickoff:** 18th-19th November 2026
- **Problem validation, ideation and solution design**: 23rd-27th November 2026
- **Virtual technical bootcamp and mentor matching:** 23rd-27th November 2026
- **Prototype development sprint, testing and documentation:** 28th November-13th December 2026
- **Prototype submission and documentation deadline**: 13th December 2026
- **Demo Day, project showcase and live judging:** 15th-16th December 2026
- **Grand Finale, Presentation of Awards and Innovation Showcase:** 16th December 2026

WHAT ARE WE EXPECTING PARTICIPANTS TO DEVELOP?

This Hackathon is designed to produce practical outputs, not just presentations. Teams are expected to identify a defined problem, develop an evidence-based approach and demonstrate a working prototype or technically credible proof of concept. Depending on the challenge track, acceptable outputs may include applications, AI models, dashboards, data tools, technical methodologies, accessible interfaces and other demonstrable solutions.

A complete submission will include:

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- A clear problem statement and explanation of the intended users.
- A prototype, demonstration or technically credible proof of concept appropriate to the track.
- Technical documentation and an explanation of the methodology.
- Evidence of testing or evaluation and an honest account of limitations.
- Responsible AI, privacy and security considerations.
- A presentation explaining the solution's potential usefulness and pathway to further development.
- A two-minute video presentation demonstrating the team's solution, explaining the problem it addresses, how it works and its potential impact. Teams are encouraged to include footage of members collaborating on the development of their solution.

Kindly note that teams are not required to submit fully developed commercial platforms. The purpose of the hackathon is to help participants make progress from a defined problem to a demonstrable innovation and take their ideas to prototype level with the hope to receive possible further support from prototype into Product.

WHAT WILL NOT BE CONSIDERED A VALID SUBMISSION?

The following are not eligible:

- Ideas-only proposals.
- Pitch decks, wireframes or presentations without a working solution.
- Mock-ups without a functional or technically credible proof of concept.
- Applications submitted in languages other than English.
- Projects that have already received grants, awards or recognition in another competition.

PRIZES AND AWARDS

The #AI4Elections Hackathon features a total ₦10 million cash prize pool across overall and special innovation awards:

- **1st Place - Overall Champion:** ₦4,000,000
- **2nd Place - Runner-up:** ₦2,500,000
- **3rd Place - Second Runner-up:** ₦1,500,000

Four additional ₦500,000 Special Innovation Awards will recognize outstanding solutions in **Research and Policy Innovation, Electoral and Civic Inclusion, Responsible AI and Safety and Cybersecurity and Resilience.**

HOW WILL PROJECTS BE JUDGED?

Submissions will be assessed against published criteria:

- Technical functionality and innovation - 25%.
- Electoral relevance and practical usefulness - 20%.
- Cybersecurity, privacy and responsible AI - 20%.
- Inclusion and accessibility - 15%.
- Scalability and feasibility - 15%.
- Demonstration and documentation - 5%.

The judging process will include relevant technical, research, electoral and civic expertise and judges will disclose conflicts of interest. The #AI4Elections Hackathon is led by Rise Networks, with opportunities for relevant public institutions, academic institutions, technology companies and electoral stakeholders to contribute technical, research, mentorship and ecosystem support. These contributions will support the development of practical, inclusive, secure and responsible AI solutions for electoral integrity and democratic participation in Nigeria.

Final details, bootcamp schedules and finalist requirements will be communicated through Rise Networks' official channels.

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IMPORTANT PROGRAMME RULES

The #AI4Elections Hackathon is a national, nonpartisan, multi-disciplinary, public-interest Programme. Participants must not use the Programme to develop partisan voter persuasion, political microtargeting, election manipulation or unauthorized access to electoral systems. Teams must only use synthetic, public or expressly authorized data. No participant may test live electoral infrastructure or access confidential institutional information without explicit written authorization.

All participants must comply with the competition's code of conduct, responsible AI requirements, intellectual property rules and applicable law. Participants will retain intellectual property rights as specified in the published competition rules and no automatic transfer of participant intellectual property to Rise Networks, INEC, sponsors or technical partners will arise merely from participation. Further participation, data protection, safeguarding and prize conditions will be communicated to applicants before onboarding.

HOW TO APPLY

Applications are open through the #AI4Elections Hackathon application portal.

1. Visit ai4elections.risenetworks.org
2. Review the application information and eligibility requirements.
3. Complete and submit the application form before the deadline.
4. Direct enquiries and requests for application support to comms@risenetworks.org.

Application deadline: 12th November 2026, 11:59 p.m. West African Time.

Applicants should be prepared to provide their relevant skills or experience, preferred challenge track, project interests, team information and a short explanation of the electoral problem they wish to address. Prior experience in developing AI systems is not mandatory for all tracks.

Ready to design and develop AI solutions?

Join a national community of innovators working to advance responsible AI, electoral integrity, inclusion and civic participation in Nigeria.

Feel free to reach out to us at **comms@risenetworks.org.**

Technical Briefs, Documentation & Resources for all Teams available at - https://github.com/Rise-Networks-AI-Labs/-AI4Elections-Hackathon

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